

resignation of a top-level executive in one of my companies. Although he was intelligent, hard-working and experienced, this man had a signal weakness that proved fatal to his career—and which, in time, might well have proved fatal to the company. He simply could not distinguish between the possible and the impossible—

and his myopia extended to matters large and small.

Typical of his costly blunders was his tendency to undertake tasks which he should have realized were patently impossible to fulfill. Also typical were his ebulliently optimistic—and completely unrealistic—estimates of the time it would take to carry out an assignment or to complete a project.

"Yes, we can do it," he'd promise with bland assurance—

even though "it" could not be done. "I'll have everything finished for you in three days," he'd say confidently—even though he must have known three **weeks** would be required to perform the work in question.

Perhaps he was driven by some compulsive desire to impress people with promises. Maybe he was afflicted with some

139

rare form of sophomania or counted on fortuitous miracles to achieve the impossibilities he was in the habit of promising so rashly. Whatever the reasons, he gradually dragged himself—and his associates, subordinates and superiors—

down into a morass of totally impractical projects, backlogged work, canceled orders and incomplete programs that had to be abandoned with consequent financial loss to the company.

This executive's inability to distinguish between the possible and the impossible created chaos within the company and alienated its customers. Brought to book for his shortcomings, he again demonstrated his fatal myopia by failing to realize that one cannot indefinitely hide one's mistakes behind glib excuses or displays of histrionics. He indulged freely in both in